

Great Houses of the Scarlet Dynasty



With a culture of military discipline and famous for its heroes, **House Cathak** boasts the greatest military might of any house. If civil war erupts, it plans to play queenmaker by throwing its force behind the most viable candidate.



Glamorous even among their peers, **House Cynis** wields rumor, blackmail, poison, and hedonistic excess as political weapons. They are masters of the Realm's slave trade, with deep ties to the Guild, and control the markets for illicit substances.



Famous for its staunch support of the Immaculate faith, **House Ledaal** refuses to focus on the politics of the race for the Throne, instead continuing their Shadow Crusade against Anathema corruption, whether found in the Realm or in the Threshold.



Still led by its puissant founder and namesake, **House Mnemon** maintains close ties to the Immaculate Order. Mnemon is the oldest surviving daughter of the Scarlet Empress and the self-proclaimed heir apparent. Renowned as architects for the manses, temples, and public works of the Realm, many Mnemon scions travel broadly and incorporate foreign styles in their work.



House Nellens is widely derided for its weak blood, lacking other houses' more numerous Dragon-Blooded, but makes up for it with political and economic influence within the Realm's ministries. Nellens is a popular house with the patrician and peasant classes, and grooms its few Dragon-Blooded scions very carefully, engaging in coordinated matchmaking to strengthen its lineage.



House Peleps controls the might of the Imperial Navy. They have a strong presence in the West, where they may have the opportunity to build a new empire. The other houses are torn between attempting to stymie them and allying with them.



House Ragara's greatest asset is its immense wealth; it ruthlessly exploits debts owed to it, even by other Dynasts. They will do anything to claim power in the Realm, including turning to heretical sorceries and blasphemous artifacts.



Derided by the other Great Houses as cruel brutes and ruthless thugs, **House Sesus'** impressive military masks its central focus on spies, saboteurs, assassins, and intrigue. Boasting strong bloodlines, they often intermarry with their Cynis and Mnemon allies.



While their Legions were shattered in battle against the Anathema warlord, the Bull of the North, **House Tepet** maintains their ancient military tradition and ethos of excellence. Now, House Tepet is a dark horse struggling to climb back to power.



House V'neef is the youngest Great House, formed by the Scarlet Empress around a favoured daughter from outcastes and Dragon-Blooded patricians, and awarded the Realm's tribute-carrying Merchant Fleet to weaken House Peleps' naval monopoly. Targeted by some of the other claimants, the Throne may be their only path to survival.



In disgrace and officially dissolved, the **Iselsi** manoeuvred against the Empress in a doomed power-play generations ago and now survive by her sufferance. Iselsi has spent decades cultivating a massive intelligence and assassination network both in the Realm and abroad in the Threshold to pursue revenge against the other houses for the indignities done to them.

Institutions of the Realm

The Scarlet Dynasty: The Scarlet Empress' vast extended family, comprising the **Great Houses** and the **cadet houses** of the Threshold.

Great House: One of the 10 aristocratic families of the Scarlet Dynasty. Each house is overseen by a matriarch, who controls its assets and exerts considerable influence in its members' lives.

Cadet Houses: A Dragon-Blooded family in the Threshold, tied by marriage to the Scarlet Dynasty.

Dynasts: A member of the Scarlet Dynasty, the Realm's ruling class.

Patricians: The Blessed Isle's administrative class, who hold prominent positions within the imperial bureaucracy.

Peasants: Make up the bulk of the Blessed Isle's populace, ranging from impoverished farmers to well-to-do merchants.

Slaves: Have no rights, but are afforded more legal protection than the dispossessed as the chattel of their masters. Only Dragon-Blooded can own slaves.

Dispossessed: Ex-citizens who've been stripped of their rights as punishment for crimes.

Outcaste: Any Dragon-Blood not belonging to the Scarlet Dynasty. Patricians who Exalt as Dragon-Blooded are typically adopted by one of the Great Houses, although some remain in their own families. A peasant, dispossessed or slave who Exalts is called a "lost egg" — and brought into the Empress' service in the legions or in the Immaculate Order.

Prefecture: An administrative division of the Blessed Isle. Overseen by a prefect.

Satrapy: A Threshold province that acknowledges the Scarlet Empress' suzerainty and pays tribute to the Realm. Overseen by a satrap who ensures that the local government pays tribute.

The Thousand Scales: The Realm's countless ministries, overseeing bureaucratic functions ranging from tax collection to foreign policy to public works.

The Deliberative: The Realm's legislative body; it held little real power under the Scarlet Empress, but in her absence, much of her power has defaulted to it.

The Magistrates: Elite agents and investigators loyal only to the Empress, empowered to investigate crimes, root out corruption, and deliver punishment.

The All-Seeing Eye: The Imperial Service's espionage arm, reporting directly to the Scarlet Empress.

The Imperial Legions: Realm armies once loyal to the Empress alone, acclaimed as Creation's greatest fighting force. Now divided up among the Great Houses.

The Imperial Navy: Five great armadas, forming the world's largest fleet. Controlled by House Peleps.

The Merchant Fleet: Ships assigned to escort the Realm's tribute to the Blessed Isle.

The Immaculate Philosophy: The Realm's state religion, which teaches that the Dragon-Blooded have attained spiritual perfection through countless cycles of reincarnation and are thus Creation's rightful rulers. The Order promises that mortals who obey the Dragon Blooded will reincarnate into better lives, with greater wealth and power. It strictly regulates the worship of Creation's gods.

The Immaculate Order: The religious institution that enforces and spreads the Immaculate Philosophy. Monks enforce Immaculate orthodoxy, wielding words and martial arts against heretics, unruly gods seeking worship beyond what the prayer calendar grants them, and Anathema.

Wyld Hunts: Hunting parties mounted by Dragon Blooded and Immaculate monks to track down and kill Anathema quickly, before their power can grow.

Secondary Schools: The Realm's rigorous academies of higher learning attended from ages 15 to 21.

The House of Bells: The Realm's premier military academy, producing Dragon-Blooded officers of the Realm's legions.

The Spiral Academy: Trains Dragon-Blooded in diplomacy, administration, and economics.

The Cloister of Wisdom: Trains those who wish to join the Immaculate Order, including lost eggs.

The Heptagram: Teaches sorcery, artifice, geomancy, and other esoteric arts.

Pasiap's Stairs: A military academy attended almost exclusively by lost eggs who chose to serve the Empress in the legions.